

Chapter-5

Conclusion, Implication, Limitation and Future Directions

5.1 Conclusion

The exploration of social emotions of shame, guilt, and remorse with the levels of appraisal illuminates certain findings and draw valuable conclusions. Guilt arises when an individual believes they have violated their own moral and ethical principles. The intensity of guilt is heightened if the wrongdoing was deliberate and leading to self-blame. The shame emotion extends beyond specific actions and prompting individuals to question their self. Further, remorse a composite emotion combines repentance and empathy emerging when individuals recognize the negative impact of their actions on others. Therefore, by relating these emotions with the levels of appraisal the certain inferences of the results of these social emotions (guilt, shame and remorse) with the levels are drawn out.

The study is mainly focus on two aims i.e. (1) explore the situations that generate the social emotions of guilt, shame and remorse, and (2) evaluate the emotional experiences of guilt, shame and remorse with the levels of appraisal.

5.1.1 Aim 1

For aim 1, the findings explored 59 situations classified to evoke the social emotions of guilt, shame, and remorse. Among the identified situations, 21 were linked to feelings of guilt, 21 to shame, and 17 to remorse. Interestingly, 15 situations overlapped in evoking both guilt and shame, while 14 were associated with guilt and remorse, and 10 with shame and remorse. The study also identified 9 specific situations (such as performance, sin, cheat, lie, separate, failure, steal, disobey, and damage) capable of eliciting all three social emotions altogether.

Therefore, determine the 59 situations of guilt, shame and remorse separately and altogether. Our findings are aligning with previous researches that similar situations can evoke guilt, shame and remorse separately and altogether. Because, the concurrent experience of guilt, shame and remorse suggests that emotions are not isolated entities but rather interlinked and shape the human behavior and experiences. Also, the factors such as personal values, cultural background, and situational context can contribute to the emotional responses observed in individuals.

Research exploring the simultaneous activation of these emotions can provide valuable insights into the intricacies of human psychology and contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of how individuals navigate and process complex emotional experiences. This understanding, in turn, can have implications for fields such as psychology, sociology, and even ethics, shedding light on the multifaceted nature of emotional responses to moral dilemmas or ethical decision-making. Thus, it infers that social emotional responses are complex multifaceted in nature and influenced by numerous factors.

5.1.2 Aim 2

5.1.2.1 Guilt Subjective Feelings State. The study emphasizes the results of chi-square test of independence and displays the significant independence in four domains (occurrence, duration, reoccurrence and intensity) of subjective feeling state by the levels of appraisal. The findings show independence in adult's guilt subject feelings of state with levels of appraisal. The results are supported by the previous studies that appraisal had a significant independence upon emotions in wide variety of situations. Thus, the experience of guilt in adults is a multifaceted psychological phenomenon influenced by various cognitive, emotional, and social aspects. Hence, it infers that individuals frequently interpret and assess situations differently based on their personal beliefs, values, and internalized moral standards.

5.1.2.2 Guilt Emotion Experiences. The results of guilt emotion experiences shed the light on findings that the high level of appraisal shows high guilt emotion experience (bodily symptoms, expressive reactions, verbal reactions and psychological consequences) as compared to moderate and low appraisal levels. Because the high guilt appraisal of the situation amplify the cortisol level leads high stress level and the individual shows more noticeable signs of distress, anxious, restlessness and withdrawing from social interaction. Further, the previous research support the findings that shame, guilt, and anger elicits different psychological, physiological, and behavioural patterns and these reactive systems influence the social adjustment of young *adults*. Because the guilt appraisal triggers bodily tension, frowns, closed-off gestures, distress verbal expressions, heightened anxiety, reduced self-esteem, and a sense of overwhelm occurs.

5.1.2.3 Shame Subjective Feelings State. The chi-square test of independence displays the significant independence of the levels of appraisal and the four (occurrence, duration, reoccurrence and intensity) domains of subjective feeling state of shame. The key findings indicate a significant independence between adults' subjective feelings and levels of appraisal. Therefore, the experience of shame in adults is a complex psychological phenomenon influenced by various cognitive, emotional, and social factors. The previous studies supporting the results suggest a broader consensus on the significant impact of appraisal on emotions in various situations. The conclusion emphasizes the individualistic nature of interpreting and assessing situations, attributing differences to personal beliefs, values, and internalized moral standards. Thus, each person brings a unique lens to understanding events, leading to diverse interpretations. This subjectivity highlights the complexity of human insight and the influence of individualistic nuances in navigating and comprehending various situations.

5.1.2.4 Shame Emotion Experiences. The results of shame emotion experiences shed the light on findings that the high level of appraisal shows high level of shame emotional experience of bodily symptoms, expressive reactions, verbal reactions and psychological consequences as compared to moderate and low appraisal levels. Because, the physiological changes associated with low levels of shame appraisal include a slight increase in heart rate, skin conductance and a mild signs of *stress reactions*. Further, the study support the findings that the low levels of shame appraisal of individual display subtle non-verbal cues such as low gazing, slumped posture, discomfort with the situation. Also, the behavioral changes lead withdrawal, desire to hide and seeking to avoid further exposure. *However*, as the level of shame appraisal intensifies, physiological responses become more pronounced, with heightened activation of the sympathetic nervous system leading to increased heart rate, sweating, and blushing. Because the physiological responses potentially leading to a state of extreme distress and individual with shame show the symptoms of minor panic attack, rapid breathing, trembling and a sense of dissociation occurs as researches *shown*. Therefore, the shame operates as a moral emotion and individuals physiological and behaviours changes are occur when shameful event happens.

5.1.2.5 Remorse Subjective Feelings State. The result shows the significant independence among the levels of appraisal and four (occurrence, duration,

reoccurrence and intensity) domains of subject feeling state of remorse. This suggests that the experience of remorse is determined by a straightforward assessment of a situation and multifaceted psychological phenomenon influenced by a combination of cognitive and social factors. The results are in line with previous studies that highlight the substantial impact of appraisal on emotions across different situations. The conclusion draws attention to the individualistic nature of how people interpret and assess situations, attributing variations to their personal beliefs, values, and internalized moral standards. In essence, each person approaches events with a unique perspective, leading to diverse interpretations of the remorse situation. This subjectivity highlights the intricacies of human insight and emphasizes the influence of individualistic nuances in navigating and understanding various circumstances.

5.1.2.6 Remorse Emotion Experiences. The findings of remorse emotion experiences shows the high level of appraisal leads high bodily symptoms, expressive reactions, verbal reactions and psychological consequences as compared to moderate and low appraisal levels. Because, remorse is complex emotion experience characterized by feelings of guilt and regret and having a desire for redemption of wrongdoing. Also, the remorse is associated with increased activation of brain regions such as the anterior insula, amygdala and prefrontal cortex as highlighted by previous studies. These regions are involved in regulating emotions and decision-making and demonstrating the physiological changes that occur during the experience of remorse. Further, the studies on the autonomic nervous system responses related to guilt and remorse have shown that individuals experiencing more increase in heart rate, perspiration and stress level. Similarly the psychological aspect of the remorse involves a profound sense of moral self-assessment and cognitive reflection. Because the experience of remorse involves a cognitive appraisal of one's actions and leads to self-reproach and internal evaluation of moral standards. Moreover, remorse often involves feelings of empathy and a desire to repair the harm caused and the person motivates for seeking forgiveness and making amends. Thus, it infers that as the level of remorse intensifies, individuals may display changes in expressive behaviour, such as increased displays of sadness, regret and attempts to communicate their feelings of remorse through non-verbal cues.

5.1.2.7 Residential Comparison. The findings show that the Jammu and Kashmir adults show higher scores on guilt emotion experiences as compared to the

Uttar-Pradesh. Because the people of Kashmir residing in the region of South Asia have a rich cultural heritage that greatly values group harmony and social cohesion. They strongly focus on collective culture, mutual respect, and collective well-being. Further, there is a strong sense of community support and mutual assistance among Kashmiri people and they follow the concepts like “Milchar” and “Baradari” so that to maintain togetherness that leads individuals to assist each other during times of need, whether it's in the form of financial help, emotional support, and societal celebrations. Therefore, any disturbances of these aspects lead to guilt among Kashmiri people.

In opposition, shifting of collective culture to individualistic culture experiences the low emotions of guilt. Because the transformation of Uttar Pradesh's collective culture into individual culture is a multifaceted process influenced by several interconnected factors. Urbanization and stitching of communities due to migration contribute to a shift towards more individualistic lifestyles, characterized by a focus on personal goals and aspirations challenging to follow traditional norms and values experiences the person guilt. It's important to recognize that this transition is not uniform and varies across communities and regions within Uttar Pradesh, with elements of collective culture often coexisting with emerging individualistic tendencies.

5.1.2.8 Gender Comparison. The findings show male adults show higher scores on shame emotion experiences as compared to the female adults. The findings support the previous researches that male experiences more shame than females particularly in contexts related to task failure and bad performance. Because of *traditional masculine schema* that they are physically strong therefore failing any public performance leads to experiences more shame than females. Whereas females experiences shame related to physical (body) patterns and failure in relationships. Because their cognition are tends to revolve around *relational failures* whereas male's shame is more related to *instrumental failures* as highlighted by previous researches.

Similarly, the findings show the female adults show higher scores on remorse emotional experiences as compared to the male adults. Because of the *societal pressures and gender socialization (social expectations)* contributes to the amplified experience of remorse among women. Therefore, women are more socializing than man and given more importance to relationships and harmony, which could intensify

their remorse responses to situations where they feel they've caused harm and disrupted social bonds. In this way, females are habitually adopting cultural norms, customs, empathy, nurturing, and emotional sensitivity that leads to heightened feelings of remorse.

5.2 Implication

By studying shame, guilt, and remorse emotions can lead to various implication:

5.2.1 *Balanced Emotional Life*

The identified situations of shame, guilt, and remorse have substantial implication for personal growth and emotional well-being. Because, recognizing these emotions related to specific situations allows individuals to address underlying problems, learn from mistakes, and make positive changes. Further, it will promote self-awareness and accountability to improve decision making and interpersonal relationships. Also, individuals can actively work towards emotional resilience, fostering a healthier and balanced emotional life.

5.2.2 *Personal and Social Development*

Personal and social development through social emotions involves enlightening emotional intelligence, empathy, and communication skills. These aspects foster positive relationships, conflict resolution, and cultural competence. By understanding and managing of guilt, shame and remorse emotions, individuals can build a foundation for meaningful connections, contributing to their overall well-being and creating a healthier social environment.

5.2.3 *Therapeutic Interventions*

Therapists and counselors can utilize to address emotions of shame, guilt, and remorse to support individuals in their healing process, emotional management, and personal development. By incorporating these targeted approaches, mental health professionals can also guide individuals towards understanding, processing, and overcoming these challenging emotions and ultimately facilitating a journey towards improved well-being and personal growth.

5.2.4 *Educational Strategies*

Understanding these social emotions can guide the development of educational strategies aimed at to encourage emotional intelligence, empathy, and

responsible behavior among students. Such insights offer valuable tools for educators to create environments that not only enhance academic learning but also contribute to the social and emotional development of students and preparing them for well-rounded and responsible citizen.

5.2.5 Cultural Variations

The exploration of cultural distinctions in assessing these social emotions not only unveils variations in norms, values, and societal expectations but also offers insights into diverse cultural frameworks. This understanding sheds light on how these emotions are perceived and expressed across different societies. By delving into these cultural intricacies, the study contributes to enhanced cultural understanding and sensitivity, fostering a broader awareness of the diverse ways in which individuals from various backgrounds experience and navigates these social emotions.

5.2.6 Social Impact and Ethics

Enhanced societal understanding of these emotions has the potential to cultivate a more empathetic and supportive community and develop a culture that values accountability and encourages personal growth. Furthermore, this knowledge may empower individuals to make ethically informed decisions, taking into account the broader consequences of their actions on both themselves and others. Ultimately, such awareness can contribute to the overall well-being and ethical fabric of the community.

5.2.7 Psychological Well-being

Recognizing and addressing emotions of guilt, shame, and remorse can enhance mental well-being by diminishing harmful patterns like self-blame and promoting self-compassion and acceptance.

5.2.8 Self-Concept and Identity Formation

By acknowledging and comprehending these social emotions, the study is graceful to aid the knowledge in the development of self-concept, self-esteem, and identity formation. This understanding provides individuals with valuable insights that can contribute positive sense of self, fostering personal growth and holistic identity development.

5.3 Limitation

5.3.1 Sample Comprising

This study limited to a sample comprising only highly qualified students and hence excluding the participants with low level education (below post-graduate) and illiterate participants. As a result, the study's potential for widespread applicability is limited.

5.3.2 Age Range

The study restricted to early adults the age group ranges from 18-30 years poses a limitation in terms of generalizability. Findings and conclusions derived from this specific age cohort might not accurately represent or be applicable to other age groups.

5.3.3 Population Restricts

The study exclusively focused on populations from only two states restricts the scope, potentially limiting the broader understanding of regional variations and reducing the generalizability of findings across a more diverse geographical landscape.

5.4 Future Directions

Certainly, understanding the complex emotions of shame, guilt, and remorse opens up numerous pathways for research and application across various domains.

5.4.1 Social Impact

More need to study the societal implication of shame, guilt, and remorse, including how these emotions affect group dynamics behaviour. This could lead to strategies for promoting empathy, forgiveness, and conflict resolution.

5.4.2 Psychometric Measurements and Interventions

Developing effective psychometric measures and interventions that could help individuals to cope and manage these social emotions in healthy ways. This might involve the contribution of different therapeutic approaches, such as dialectical behaviour therapy (DBT), acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), cognitive-behavioural therapy (CBT) and mindfulness-based interventions.

5.4.3 Neuro-scientific Research

Explore the neurological basis of these emotions to better understand their neural pathways, micro facial expressions and brain regions involved. This could lead to insights into treatments and interventions targeting these specific neural mechanisms.

5.4.4 Cultural and Ethical Perspectives

Investigating how different cultures and ethical frameworks view these emotions and their impact on individuals within these contexts. This research could help in developing culturally sensitive approaches to address these emotions.

5.4.5 Legal and Criminal Justice Systems

Assessing how these emotions impact behaviour, rehabilitation, and re-offense rates within the criminal justice system. This could inform healing justice practices and alternative approaches to rehabilitation.

5.4.6 Self-compassion and Resilience

Promoting self-compassion practices and resilience-building techniques can empower individuals to navigate these emotions in a manner that fosters personal growth and psychological well-being and reducing the detrimental effects of shame, guilt, and remorse on mental wellbeing.

Maulana Azad Library, Aligarh Muslim University